land. Beyond that shortlist, there's not much else made by humans that's identifiable from hundreds of miles up in the sky. You can see plenty of natural scenery, though, including hurricanes in the Gulf of Mexico, ice floes in the North Atlantic, and volcanic eruptions wherever they occur.

From the Moon, a quarter million miles away, New York, Paris, and the rest of Earth's urban glitter doesn't even show up as a twinkle. But from your lunar vantage you can still watch major weather fronts move across the planet. From Mars at its closest, some thirty-five million miles away, massive snow-capped mountain chains and the edges of Earth's continents would be visible through a large backyard telescope. Travel out to Neptune, three billion miles away—just down the block on a cosmic scale—and the Sun itself becomes a thousand times dimmer, now occupying a thousandth the area on the daytime sky that it occupies when seen from Earth. And what of Earth itself? It's a speck no brighter than a dim star, all but lost in the glare of the Sun.

A celebrated photograph taken in 1990 from just beyond Neptune's orbit by the *Voyager 1* spacecraft shows just how underwhelming Earth looks from deep space: a "pale blue dot," as the American astrophysicist Carl Sagan called it. And that's generous. Without the help of a caption, you might not even know it's there.

What would happen if some big-brained aliens from the great beyond scanned the skies with their naturally superb visual organs, further aided by alien state-of-the-art optical accessories? What visible features of planet Earth might they detect?

Blueness would be first and foremost. Water covers more than two-thirds of Earth's surface; the Pacific Ocean alone spans nearly an entire side of the planet. Any beings with enough equipment and expertise to detect our planet's color would surely infer the presence of water, the third most abundant molecule in the universe.

If the resolution of their equipment were high enough, the aliens would see more than just a pale blue dot. They would see intricate coastlines, too, strongly suggesting that the water is liquid. And smart aliens would surely know that if a planet has liquid water, then the planet's temperature and atmospheric pressure fall within a well-determined range.

Earth's distinctive polar ice caps, which grow and shrink from the seasonal temperature variations, could also be seen using visible light. So could our planet's twenty-four-hour rotation, because recognizable landmasses rotate into view at predictable intervals of time. The aliens would also see major weather systems come and go; with careful study,